TWELVE SIMPLE IDEAS / 11 NOVEMBER 2026

COUNT ONCE

A laser that kills weeds without touching the crop. A camera that counts cows in a dark barn. Both do the same thing: look at everything, act on one thing, leave the rest alone. Here is that idea, applied to people.

MIND	People in crisis
WATER	Sea and flood
CARE	Hospitals and homes
MOTION	Road and yard
WORLD	Land and pipes

THE IDEA / TWO MACHINES, ONE PATTERN

A laser that kills weeds.
A camera that counts cows.

THE LASER

It sees every plant, knows which is a weed, and burns only the weed. Five thousand times a minute. It does not spray the field.

THE COW CAMERA

It sees every cow, keeps track of each one, and counts it once as it walks through the door. Even in the dark, even when they crowd together.

Look

A cheap camera or sensor sees every unit.

Decide

The model says: this one, not that one.

Act

A small action, on that one only.

THE PATTERN

Look at everything, cheaply. Decide one thing at a time. Act on that one thing only. Then check that everything else was left alone.

THE PROMISE / COUNT, DO NOT IDENTIFY

We count people.
We do not know who they are.

The cameras count bodies and directions. They do not store faces, names or files. A count can save a life. A face is a different product, and we are not building it.

WHAT THE SYSTEM KEEPS

A number: how many people, and which way they went. For how long the safety plan says, and no longer.

WHAT IT NEVER KEEPS

Faces, names, addresses, phone numbers, or anything that fits a person to a record.

Call them on day two

THE PROBLEM

The two weeks after someone leaves a mental health ward are the most dangerous weeks of their life. Today the plan is a letter and a date.

WHAT WE DO

A named person rings them on day two. Not a form. A call, from someone who has read their safety plan.

1. Day two: one nurse, one call.
2. Week one: the plan is checked together, in words.
3. Missed call: the same nurse tries again that day.

THE NUMBER

0.2% vs 2.2%

deaths at 18 months. 0.2% when a person called and stayed in contact, 2.2% with standard care. 1,867 people, five countries.

WHO Bulletin, Fleischmann et al., 2008

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

About £150 per person for the calls.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

No one loses a right. Refusing texts never cancels the call, and the patient reads the same notes as the clinician.

Fix the rota, not the person

THE PROBLEM

Work makes people ill, and the answer is usually a wellbeing app aimed at the person who is already ill.

WHAT WE DO

Ask the team, anonymously, what the job does to them. Then change the rota, the caseload or the manager.

1. An anonymous survey the staff own.
2. The clinical score stays with the clinic.
3. Change one thing. Measure again.

THE NUMBER

$1 trillion

a year lost to depression and anxiety at work, and 12 billion working days.

WHO, mental health at work, 2024

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

One survey and one rota change. No software at first.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

No one's answers reach their boss. Groups under ten report nothing, and staff see the report before managers do.

Count the beach

THE PROBLEM

A tsunami warning says a wave is coming. Nobody knows how many people are standing on the sand, or where they went.

WHAT WE DO

Cameras already on the seafront count people on the beach and which way they walk. It cannot see the wave. It answers the question the warning leaves open.

1. Use the cameras the harbour already has.
2. Count each person once. No faces.
3. Before: get them off. After: count who is missing.

THE NUMBER

227,899

people killed or missing in the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami. Most had no warning at all.

NOAA National Centers for Environmental Information, 2014

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

A feed from a camera the harbour already owns.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

It counts people, it does not watch them. No faces stored, no names, and it cannot stop anyone leaving.

Count who is still inside

THE PROBLEM

A flood warning goes out and the town is told to leave. Nobody knows who is still inside, so evacuation is assumed.

WHAT WE DO

Cameras on the roads into the zone count people going in and coming out. A gap that does not close by the deadline becomes a list of doors to knock on.

1. Count in and out at the three roads into the zone.
2. Sirens and door knocks first. A count comes after.
3. A gap that stays open: name the street, send a boat.

THE NUMBER

75%

of the 190 people who died in Germany's 2021 floods were outside the official danger maps.

Rhein and Kreibich, Natural Hazards and Earth System Sciences, 2025

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

Cameras on three roads. No new network.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

It counts at roads, not in homes. No faces, no address lists, and the count can only send help to a door.

Count the boat

THE PROBLEM

A small boat is spotted offshore. Nobody knows how many people are on it, so the rescue is sent blind.

WHAT WE DO

A camera counts heads on the boat and the direction it is moving. The rescue crew knows how many seats to bring.

1. A drone or a clifftop camera.
2. Counts people sitting, lying, and packed together.
3. One number, sent to the rescue boat.

THE NUMBER

82

people died or went missing in the Channel in 2024. 36,816 people arrived in small boats.

IOM Missing Migrants, 2025; UK Home Office, 2025

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

A drone already in the air, plus software.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

A count, not a passport. No faces, no names, and no list of who was on board.

Count the crowd

THE PROBLEM

Crowds are let into a space until it is too late to see that it is too full.

WHAT WE DO

A camera counts people in and out of each pen. Entry gates stop at the number the safety plan allows.

1. Count each person once, even in a dark crowd.
2. Which way they walk tells in from out.
3. Gates close at 4 people per square metre.

THE NUMBER

769

people died in one crush at Mina in 2015, out of more than 1.95 million pilgrims.

Saudi Ministry of Health, final Hajj statement, 2015

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

Cameras the venue already owns.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

A number, not a face. No identification, no tracking after the night, and nothing kept once the event ends.

Count who leaves the ward

THE PROBLEM

People with dementia walk out of care homes and hospital wards. Some are found hurt. Some are not found for hours.

WHAT WE DO

A camera at the door counts each person crossing it and which way they go. Someone going out, alone, is one alert.

1. One camera at the door, none in rooms.
2. Each person counted once, no faces stored.
3. Out without staff: one phone rings.

THE NUMBER

40,000

missing incidents a year in the UK, about one every 13 minutes. 9.4% end in serious harm.

BBC News, 2026; UCL analysis of 1,540 police records, 2021

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

About £900 per door, per year.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

The hardest case. A blurred face can still be known by height and walk, so the camera counts movement only, keeps no images, and wipes at the end of each shift.

The urine test that should not prescribe

THE PROBLEM

A confused older person, a urine test, and an antibiotic ordered by phone. The test cannot tell infection from a harmless bug, so the drug is given to everyone.

WHAT WE DO

Staff record what they actually see. A doctor decides. Often the answer is water, a review, or a wait with a clock on it.

1. Signs captured at the bedside in a minute.
2. Separate infection from dehydration or a drug.
3. A doctor signs the drug, or signs a watch plan.

THE NUMBER

2.81

antibiotic courses per care home resident a year, across 235 homes. One avoided hospital admission saves about £5,000.

BMC Health Services Research, 2020; UKHSA, 2025

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

£1,500 per home, per year.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

A doctor always signs. A watch plan cannot renew itself, and red flags skip the model and go to a human.

Four minutes earlier

THE PROBLEM

Care homes check every bed every two hours. That wakes the people who were never going to fall, and spreads attention thin.

WHAT WE DO

Sensors watch bed exits and the path to the toilet. One nurse goes to the right bed, four minutes earlier.

1. A sensor under the bed. Nothing worn.
2. Awake and steady: no alert. Unsteady: alert.
3. One nurse, one bed, earlier.

THE NUMBER

43%

fewer falls with a targeted programme, at £108 per resident. Falls cost the NHS about £2 billion a year.

NIHR ARC East Midlands, 2025

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

£48 per resident, per year.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

It can add a check, never cancel one. It cannot suggest a rail, a restraint or sedation.

Book the bay, not the buzzer

THE PROBLEM

A tired lorry driver gets a beep. There is nowhere to stop, so the driver keeps going.

WHAT WE DO

The truck books and pays for the next parking space ahead, and the delivery slot moves with it.

1. A camera reads lane position, not the face.
2. Tired, distracted, or a fault: three answers.
3. One bay booked. One slot moved.

THE NUMBER

25%

of fatal and serious crashes involve tiredness, and a tired-driver crash is 50% more likely to kill.

RoSPA, 2024

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

About £20 per truck, per month.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

The truck is scored, never the driver. Nothing goes in a personnel file, and the union sees the rules first.

Check the strap before the gate

THE PROBLEM

Two thousand lorries a year are stopped with loads that can come off and kill someone.

WHAT WE DO

Sensors on the straps check tension as the truck leaves the yard, not on the motorway.

1. Tension in each strap, read at the gate.
2. A strap that settled after a mile is not a fault.
3. Flag one strap. Never stop a truck at speed.

THE NUMBER

2,000

vehicles a year found with an unsafe load and banned from moving. That is one every four hours.

DVSA, load security, 2025

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

About £300 per trailer, once.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

The camera watches the load, never the cab. The data can blame a loading bay, and often does.

Hear the leak

THE PROBLEM

Water companies dig up a street for one broken joint, or replace miles of pipe because a district is losing water.

WHAT WE DO

Two cheap microphones in the pipes find the leak's address, so the crew digs one hole.

1. Listeners clamped in valve chambers.
2. Two nights of sound on the same main.
3. One map point for the crew.

THE NUMBER

346m m^3

of water lost every day around the world. About $39 billion a year, at a cautious price.

Liemberger and Wyatt, Water Supply, 2019

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

About £400 per listener, once.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

No digging on one sensor. Trunk mains need two kinds of proof and a human decision.

Trip one wire, not the county

THE PROBLEM

Power lines start fires. Utilities cut power to whole counties because one short piece of wire faulted.

WHAT WE DO

The fault is found on one span. One switch opens. The hospital stays on.

1. Reclosers, cameras and satellites are already there.
2. Separate a real fault from a bird or a branch.
3. Open one switch. Send one crew.

THE NUMBER

85

people died in the Camp Fire, started by power lines: 153,336 acres and 18,804 buildings.

CAL FIRE, 2025

WHAT IT MIGHT COST

Software on switches already installed.

Our estimate, not a quote.

WHY IT IS SAFE

Two independent signals before any switch opens. In extreme fire weather, the safe answer is off.

START HERE

Build three. Prove them in public.

All twelve are technically similar. The difference is who signs the cheque, and how fast they can sign it.

RANK	IDEA	WHY THIS ONE FIRST	COST
01	The urine test	A care home can buy it inside one budget cycle. The harm is counted in prescriptions and admissions.	£1,500 PER HOME
02	Count the beach	The cameras are already on the seafront. The first customer is a council or harbour with a duty it cannot currently meet.	ONE CAMERA FEED
03	Call them on day two	Twenty years of randomised evidence, and nobody has built the cheap thing that sits between a text and a police visit.	PER PATIENT

THE HONEST PAGE

The count can be wrong.

Every one of these systems will be wrong sometimes. The difference between a useful system and a dangerous one is what it does when it is not sure.

THE MODEL DRIFTS

The world changes and the model does not. Site by site, class by class, accuracy is measured. When it falls, the system says so and asks for help. It never quietly carries on.

IT COUNTS THE WRONG THING

Two people hugging look like one. A wheelchair looks like a chair. Confident and wrong is the dangerous state. So the system can say 'I do not know', and a human decides.

PEOPLE STOP CHECKING

A person watching 400 alerts an hour stops watching. We measure how often staff disagree with the machine. If that number falls to zero, the system is broken, not proven.

ONE LINE

Look at everything. Act on one thing. Prove you left the rest alone.

The machine is never the point. The point is the field that is still standing, the crowd that got home, and the record that shows it.